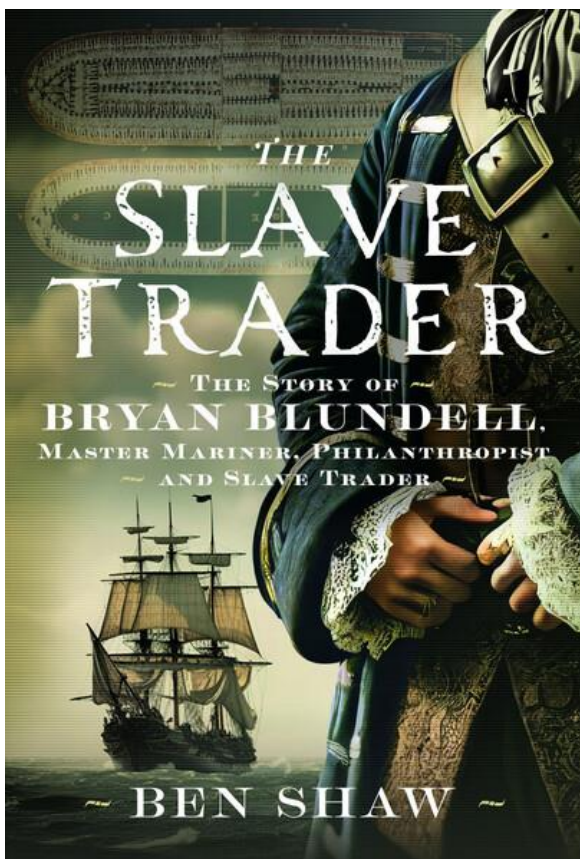


## Book Review

Shaw B (2026) *The Slave Trader: The Story of Bryan Blundell, Master Mariner, Philanthropist and Slave Trader*. Barnsley: Pen & Sword.

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Liverpool in the 1600s was a lively trading town, with the port just beginning to grow, eventually to rival Bristol and even London. It was a time of opportunities. Within just a few decades after the Jamestown Colony had been set up in Virginia (1606-07), the pattern of Liverpool's foreign trade in tobacco, sugar, cotton and rum was beginning to emerge. By 1668, Liverpool had gained its first sugar refinery. Industry followed agriculture as factories sprang up on the banks of the River Mersey and across North West England. Moreover, these commodities-which required intensive supplies of labour-were instrumental in shaping the demand for the supply of slaves in the colonies.



To provide a quick measure of just how fast things were moving in the port of Liverpool, a comparison of custom's revenue is made: in 1669 the figure was £1875; by 1686 this had risen to £14,550. Dramatic events, including the Plague of London (1655) and the Great Fire of London, the following year, served the rapid development of Liverpool as an alternative northern port. Similarly, the Dutch attacks on the southern England ports of the Thames and Medway enhanced the relative security of Liverpool, which was by the mid-1600s well on the way to becoming one of England's leading ports. Against a background of intense growth the sea-going career of Bryan Blundell took shape.

Born in 1675, the young mariner was well placed to enter into the burgeoning trades with both the Caribbean and the Americas. His home-port of Liverpool was beginning to flourish as increasing amounts of commodities passed through the port. The trade of slaves from Africa to the Caribbean and American East

coast was beginning to register positively in the profit and loss accounts of Liverpool shipowners. For the young Blundell, with his driven intent on a seagoing career, especially a career that would serve as a stepping-stone to ship-owning and as a foundation in maritime trade, the young forward thinking port of Liverpool presented very tangible opportunities.

The epithet of master mariner is clearly deserved, given the number of hazardous voyages completed by Blundell. The focus was on Caribbean and North Atlantic routes but, additionally, trips to the less well charted Madagascar and the Arctic White Sea were successfully undertaken. The combination of both philanthropist and slave-trader (as stated in this book's sub-title) leads to something of a dichotomy. As a key donor protagonist and financial supporter of the Blue Coat school in Liverpool, Blundell can be viewed as a benefactor of orphaned local children, providing them with educational opportunities in the growing city. Conversely, as a leading slave-trader he becomes much less a kind benefactor of poor people and much more a persecutor of the dispossessed African tribal peoples. That these two contrasting positions could be sustained in Christian British society points to the double standards of this period of intense economic growth.

Ben Shaw writes with a verve that captures the energy of the growing port and its people. Twenty seven years before the birth of Bryan Blundell, the 1648 arrival of the **Friendship**, with her 30 ton cargo of Virginia tobacco in barrels, represents a novel new cargo flow into Liverpool. The scene of the crew balancing on planks covering the mud banks, in haste to off-load the barrels is well portrayed. The energy outlined animates the description. The impression is of dynamic industry and commerce at work. The creation of the world's first wet-dock system in 1715 brought great advantages in cargo handling, ergo improved vessel turnaround times. For the young Bryan Blundell this was a childhood of maritime wonder. Every docking brought imported cargoes and a fresh wave of sailors and their tales of the high-seas, of piracy, masts split by lightening, of ships on fire, of mysterious foreign lands and, the never-ending tragedy of men either falling from the mast or washed overboard.

Sailing day, especially after a long wait for favourable tides and winds brought a spectacular display of sail with a mass departure of vessels intent on making as much of the ebb-tide as possible. Twenty or thirty sailing craft beating down-river, determined to clear the Mersey Bar before the end of the ebb, would have been the inspiring view of the young cabin boy on his first trip to

sea. Forming into convoys also brought a concentration of sail, with the additional excitement of Royal Navy protection from pirates.

Ben Shaw makes good use of the contemporary sermons of the Liverpool based non-conformist, Reverend Christopher Bassnett, who adds a moral dimension to the slave-trading controversy. Whilst the economic attractions of the slave-trade were paramount in Britain, the inhumanity of the business was ignored. Breaking the silence, the Reverend Bassnett preached against the evils of the lucrative trade. Unmoved by this, the impression we gain of Blundell is of a hard driving trader, intent on enjoying the economic returns on the carriage of slaves. In this, Blundell was not alone as the pursuit of the potential riches of the trade were avidly sought by many traders. The ambiguity of the moral dichotomy appears not to have led to too many sleepless nights for Blundell and his fellow traders. Liverpool (as well as the ports of London and Bristol) cruelly exploited the vulnerability of the African labour sources whilst counting the profits of their exploitation strategy. Protected by royal privilege, merchant organisations such as the Royal African Company (RAC) gave way to free enterprise., opening up opportunities for traders such as Bryan Blundell. The slave-trade had been dominated by London traders, following the loss of the London based RAC's exclusive rights in 1698, openings for the private merchants of Bristol and Liverpool appeared. The RAC had controlled the slave trade out of West African ports; Bryan Blundell's ships had initially been denied access and were forced around the Cape of Good Hope to access Madagascar's supply of slaves to the Caribbean and North America.

Ben Shaw deserves commendation for this work. The sensitive nature of the slave-trading topic is one that gains immediate attention in today's society. It is made evident that Blundell and his immediate ancestors were active purveyors of the slave-trading malpractice in the years up to its abolition and even then were reluctant to desist. As a descendant of Blundell, Ben Shaw faced a writing task that was made even-more a 'high-wire act'. His meticulous attention to research detail and referencing have made a huge contribution to expunging the silence on the slave-trade that once pervaded.

Finally, LMS Members can be particularly proud of the painstaking work of their intrepid former Vice President, the late Harry Hignett, in transcribing public records. Harry must have spent many long hours in the Liverpool Records Office!

Dr. Mervyn Rowlinson. 15.09.26